

contentment, satisfaction, and happiness now, at our current earning levels, *will* follow us into higher-income-earning brackets.

Thanks to this iron-clad science, we don't have to be fearful of making more. If anything, there's a strong encouragement to seek out ways to increase our earning potential. Especially when we can confidently manage our money well, then improving our life, earning more, or spending more is not the enemy. A change in lifestyle or increase of income doesn't automatically mean devastation of contentment. We can aim for something as long as it's informed and we're sure it's actually what we want. We don't have to worry about not being able to control ourselves or thinking that more money means more problems.

What we achieve through our careers won't be our ultimate happiness, but it also doesn't mean achieving more will be our ultimate destruction. You can keep going and be informed as you go. Pursuing contentment along the way. Both when you don't have the high-paying job *and* when you do. Contentment can be found in it all *and* be paired with new, different, and increased goals.

Paying Off Debt

Collectively, households in America have a lot of debt. And Millennials take the cake on having acquired the most debt of anyone. According to the Federal Reserve Bank of New York,⁴ in just one quarter, total household debt rose by \$212 billion. In that same quarter, credit card balances rose by \$50 billion and auto-loan balances rose by \$12 billion. Loan delinquency rates also increased across all debt types, except student loans; Nelnet takes no prisoners.

These are big numbers. So huge they almost become unimportant because none of us can really wrap our heads around what billions and trillions of dollars means. But what all this math does tell us is that we're taking on more debt and we're becoming less concerned about paying off that debt. Complacency creep anyone?

Jen and I are truly in the radical middle on debt. Between the two of us we've paid off over \$130K of debt and we've both taken out car loans in the years since. We don't think debt is dumb nor do we believe there's good debt. We believe debt is neutral. What we do with our debt and how we